

VEENA SIKRI

GUEST COLUMN

Hasina's Big Challenge

On July 31, Sheikh Hasina may have become the longest serving prime minister of Bangladesh with a total of 20 years (though not consecutively) at the helm, but she has been on the backfoot ever since the recent, explosive protests by college/ university students over reservation for government jobs resulted in around 200 deaths. That's because in Bangladesh, students have been in the vanguard of national politics, as opinion leaders and dynamic participants. Since the 1971 Liberation War, Bangladesh has had a provision for a 30 per cent quota in civil service and public sector jobs for children of freedom fighters. There was an oft-stated sub-text that beneficiaries of this quota were an important part of Hasina's Awami League vote-bank. Despite this, in October 2018, when widespread students' protests sought quota reform, it was PM Hasina who agreed to abolish all reservation. When the Dhaka High Court reversed this decision on June 5, 2024, thereby restoring quotas, and students' groups were again out on the streets (this time opposing the court's decision), the Hasina government immediately filed an appeal in the Supreme Court, making it clear that they were not interested in continuing with the quota.

All this, however, changed beginning July 15. The Dhaka University students' group started calling themselves 'razakars' (a generic term for those who opposed the Liberation War of 1971), having apparently misunderstood Sheikh Hasina's reference to this term in her press conference the previous day. The Awami League's students' wing (Bangladesh Chhatra League) stepped in to oppose the students' groups. Meanwhile, students' wings of Opposition political parties, notably the Islami Chhatra Shibir (ICS) of the Jamaat-e-Islami and the Jatiotabadi Chhatra Dal (JCD) of the BNP (Bangladesh Nationalist Party) unleashed massive violence on the streets of Dhaka. On July 18, the army was deployed in support of the government and a complete curfew and communications blackout was imposed.

While the situation is limping back to normalcy, these traumatic events have caused angst and serious concern among all sections of the people of Bangladesh, going far beyond the starting point of students' protests. The disruptors are the political parties who chose not to participate in the January 2024 elections (the BNP) or were debarred from participation (Jamaat-e-Islami). They sought to take over the students' agitation to force regime change by getting Sheikh Hasina to resign. The army succeeded in bringing the situation under control, but interested voices are reacting by calling for a ban on the Bangladesh Army's participation in UN Peace Keeping Operations. Every effort is being made to convince the world that it is the students' protests that morphed into a regime change agitation, without any mention of the incendiary role of the Jamaat's ICS and the BNP's JCD.

AFP



The stakes are high for New Delhi, as any political instability in Bangladesh can spread to neighbouring regions of India

Meanwhile, student leaders of the apolitical Quota Reform Movement (QRM) have distanced themselves from the violence. After the Supreme Court's judgement on July 21 restricting all quotas to a maximum of seven per cent, including five per cent for children of freedom fighters, students' groups placed a moratorium on their protests. They have prepared a list of nine demands, including the release of detained students, fixing responsibility for the killing of students, compensation for families of the grieving and injured and resignation of key government ministers. The government has now set up a National Inquiry Commission to investigate the killings and all related issues of the QRM. It has also announced that the Jamaat-e-Islami, already de-registered as a political party in 2018 following a High Court ruling, and Shibir are being banned.

But this tragic series of events has affected every citizen and weakened not just Sheikh Hasina but all of Bangladesh. The government of India correctly maintained that this is an internal matter for Bangladesh to resolve. India's overriding concern is that there should be political stability and continued development in Bangladesh. The stakes for India are high, as any instability in Bangladesh has the potential to spread to neighbouring regions of India. ■

(The author is a former High Commissioner of India to Bangladesh)